MISERIA

MARÍA ZABAY

A novel about power and those who live off it

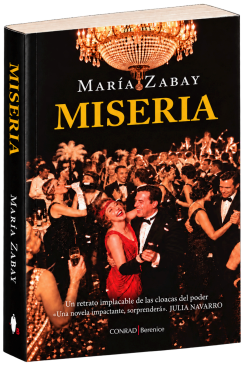


“A striking novel that will take you by surprise.”

JULIA NAVARRO

“Alonso Vega is a character who irritates, entertains and fascinates in equal measure. A fierce novel, impossible to put down.”

LUIS ALBERTO DE CUENCA



BERENICE · CONRAD

First edition · October 2026

Miseria lays bare the private world of power through the lucid, corrosive voice of one of its heirs

María Zabay's new novel turns a death in the family, a corporate inheritance and a long-suppressed agreement into an exploration of corruption, desire and conscience, led by a voice that unsettles, entertains and forces us to confront the cracks beneath apparently successful lives.

Madrid. After the sudden death of Rodrigo Vega de Saliente, founder of one of Spain's largest infrastructure empires, his son Alonso inherits far more than a company. Amid a sale to a sovereign wealth fund, a hostile takeover bid, an investigation by the Civil Guard's Central Operational Unit (UCO), and the tensions of a love life governed by the same urge to dominate as his business dealings, a forgotten contract emerges that could change the origins and ownership of the family fortune.

Told in the first person, Miseria places the reader inside a brilliant, sarcastic mind morally entangled in everything it despises. Alonso does not observe the rot from outside: he grew up in it, profits from it and perpetuates it. The tension stems as much from legal and corporate threats as from a more uncomfortable question: what remains of a man when he discovers that his identity was built on betrayal?

SUCCESS AS A FORM OF FEAR

Alonso has almost everything we are supposed to want. Yet every conquest increases what he fears losing. The intrigue of Miseria raises a question: how much of our ambition have we chosen, and how much have we learned to obey?

The emergence of the names Damián and Alba Villalba shifts the novel from Madrid's offices to Cangas de Onís. Set against money, private clubs, foundations and corporate transactions, Alba's life opens up a different system of values. The contrast between these worlds forces Alonso to confront, for the first time, a form of power he can neither buy nor intimidate.

With incisive prose, black humour and a fierce eye for the economic elite, Miseria combines narrative tension with introspection. The novel explores the murky depths of business and politics, but also of family life: inherited silences, self-serving loyalties and the ability to turn love, sex or protection into bargaining tools.

> *"A striking novel that will take you by surprise." — Julia Navarro*

An inheritance that could destroy everything

“When everything can be bought, truth becomes the most dangerous asset.”

TITLE

Miseria

Novel · 268 pages

AUTHOR

María Zabay

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PUBLICATION

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Publisher’s synopsis

Alonso Vega de Saliente learns of his father’s death at one of the most sordid moments of his life. Now heir to PUENTIA, an infrastructure empire built on public contracts, middlemen and favours, he must close a multibillion-euro deal while the UCO tightens its grip on those around him. In the patriarch’s safe he finds a 1984 agreement: the engineer Damián Villalba was to receive up to seventy-five per cent of the company for creating a revolutionary cement. Damián died young, and his daughter Alba lives unaware of the fortune that might have been hers. As an ambitious mistress, a fixer from the underworld of power and a family trained never to ask questions threaten to hasten the collapse, Alonso must decide whether to protect the family name or, for the first time, break with the moral logic that made him powerful.

High tension on the outside. Introspection within.

Miseria portrays a world of immaculate appearances and privately devastated lives. Its characters make us ask what happens when a broken person reaches the absolute limit: whether the final fall destroys them completely or whether, at precisely that moment, redemption becomes possible.

POWER

Not an abstraction, but an embodied habit: who enters, who waits, who calls, who serves, and who can turn an illegal act into routine administration.

INHERITANCE

Alonso inherits a company and a method. The decisive legacy is moral rather than material: learning to see harm to others as natural.

DESIRE

Sex, attention, recognition and domination belong to the same marketplace. Intimate relationships reproduce the hierarchies of the boardroom.

CONSCIENCE

The conflict begins when Alonso realises that resembling his father is no longer a suspicion, but a means of survival.

TRUTH

The documents exist, but they are not enough. In Miseria, truth acquires value only when someone agrees to pay its price.

REDEMPTION

Hitting rock bottom is not enough. Facing the abyss, Alonso must choose between protecting the sham that sustains his power and trying to save himself from himself.

APPEARANCES AND THEIR DEMANDS

Miseria takes the thriller into the territory of learned desires. In the circus of ambition, appearances are another conquest requiring vigilance: preserving rank, maintaining an image, keeping the cracks hidden. Power can become dependency. What is extreme about Alonso is the scale of his life, not necessarily his fears.

Alonso Vega de Saliente

The heir who becomes a witness against himself

With lucid, brilliant and unsparing prose, María Zabay gives Alonso Vega de Saliente a corrosive, unsettling and at times irresistibly comic voice, akin to the moral ferocity of Houellebecq and to John Self in Martin Amis's Money, yet rooted in the economic and family elites of contemporary Spain.

Alonso is not designed to be admirable or likeable. His magnetism springs from a contradiction: he has extraordinary insight into the pretence, vanity and rot around him, but uses that same intelligence to justify his own degradation. He is scathing about the society he inhabits, his family and himself. His cruelty irritates, the precision of his gaze makes us laugh, and he ultimately moves us when he discovers that he can no longer watch his own life from a distance.

He is Isabel's husband and the father of Pablo and Mateo. For years he has had an affair with Mónica, with whom he has a son, Alonsito. His private life is organised into compartments, payments and silences. Rodrigo's death, the discovery of Damián's contract and Alba's arrival disrupt that system.

Alba, and the discovery of the betrayal of her father, reveal that the empire and Alonso's own identity rest on a lie. Facing an abyss he can no longer close with money, lawyers or influence, he must choose between saving his fortune, his power and his image as an untouchable man, or trying to save himself from what he has become. Hitting rock bottom does not redeem him: it merely forces him to decide.

AN EXTRAORDINARY LIFE OUTSIDE, ALMOST UNLIVEABLE WITHIN

Alonso's degradation and excesses explore a kind of misery that cannot be measured by a lack of resources: it emerges when money, sex and status become the sole measures of a person's worth. His insight does not protect him from self-deception; often it gives him better arguments to sustain it.

"The only thing that disarms Alonso, in all his misery, is goodness. The only superiority I recognise is goodness."
María Zabay

An architecture of money, service and silence

The family is no refuge from power: it is its first school. Immaculate homes, domestic staff, surnames, elite education and social rituals sustain a structure in which everyone knows part of the truth and almost no one wants to put it into words.

THE FOUNDER
RODRIGO

He turns ambition into virtue and ruthlessness into a method. He dies at the outset, but continues to rule through documents, secrets and mechanisms of control.

THE ACCOMPLICE
THE MOTHER

She manages family decorum and turns betrayal into “strategy”. Her refusal to remember reveals an active form of complicity.

THE WIFE
ISABEL

She sustains the family, the children and their public respectability. Alonso mistakes her patience for resignation and is slow to notice that she too observes and decides.

THE CHILDREN
PABLO AND MATEO

They reveal both repetition and rupture. Alonso recognises his grandfather’s character in Pablo; with Mateo, a tenderness emerges that he barely knows how to express.

THE HOUSEHOLD’S MEMORY
JOSEFINA

The woman who cared for Alonso knows the history the family has excluded from its archives. She preserves the link to Damián and Alba and, through a quiet intervention, sets Alonso on the trail of the true heiress.

THE PARALLEL INHERITANCE
ALONSITO

The son of Alonso and Mónica reveals that even intimate life has been organised like a set of secret accounts.

WHAT WE INHERIT WITHOUT KNOWING

In Miseria, far more than money is inherited: a moral code is passed down. What success means, whom we should respect and what we are entitled to do. Families transmit explanations of the world that can come into conflict with who we are.

Isabel, Mónica and Alba

RESISTANCE

ISABEL

Alonso's wife and the mainstay of family life. She represents a form of resistance he cannot interpret because he has never fully considered his wife's inner life. Isabel observes, understands and decides.

"Do you know the worst part? […] That I still care about you."

BOUNDLESS AMBITION

MÓNICA

Alonso's mistress, Alonsito's mother and the face of the foundation, she refuses to remain in the shadows. She wants more than money: she seeks recognition, legitimacy and power. She uses seduction, information, emotional blackmail and threats until affection becomes a bargaining tool.

"You are mine […] She sought domination. It was her way of feeling pleasure."

THE MORAL MEASURE

ALBA

Damián's daughter and a teacher in Cangas de Onís. She lives outside elite circles. Her refusal of money is judgement, not naivety: by rejecting what Alonso considers irresistible, she exposes the moral poverty of his world.

"The truth will absolve neither your father nor you […] And it is no use to me either. Leave."

The inventor, the fixer and the lawyer

THE ERASED ORIGIN
DAMIÁN VILLALBA

Engineer and creator of Alba Cement. In 1984 he signs an agreement with Rodrigo that should make him the owner of up to 75% of PUVISA. Trust between former colleagues takes the place of notarisation. After the betrayal, he returns to Cangas and dies young in an accident.

THE TECHNICIAN
PACO MONREAL

Lawyer and survivor. He never asks whether something should be done, only how. He knows the company's origins, serves Rodrigo and then Alonso, and turns moral decisions into legally defensible operations.

THE LEGAL SHIELDS
FERLOSIO AND CUENCA

They represent two levels of the same industry: the fixer who manages contacts and the criminal lawyer who can turn suspicion into a defensible narrative.

THE UNDERWORLD OF POWER
HUGO

Middleman, keeper of secrets and executor of jobs the powerful need to deny. He knows too much to be dispensable and too little to feel safe. His power comes from other people's files.

THE SILENT WITNESS
FÉLIX

Alonso's chauffeur. His constant presence underlines the boundary between the person who chooses the route and the person who drives. He observes the heir's degradation without seeking to interpret it aloud.

EXTERNAL PRESSURE
GARRIDO AND THE UCO

The investigation is more than a threat of prosecution. It forces the narrator to see himself from outside, reduced to a case file, a leak and a potential headline.

Madrid: the city of access

The Madrid of Miseria is not a postcard, but a network of permissions. Torre Europa, Puerta de Hierro, Fortuny, restaurants, secure offices, clubs and private boxes form a geography in which space expresses rank. The city offers speed, connections and anonymity; it also demands constant exposure.

Alonso travels in chauffeur-driven cars, corporate lifts, glass-walled rooms and houses where domestic staff maintain an immaculate normality. Each setting looks clean because the dirt has been displaced into contracts, middlemen and opaque accounts. The cultural foundation adds a veneer of respectability: art and philanthropy as the stage set for wealth.

Madrid is also the territory of the public narrative. Here a death becomes a reputational crisis, a private matter becomes a leak and a crime becomes a media debate. The press, politics and business are not three separate worlds, but adjoining rooms.

A city where power need not show itself: knowing which door opens, and for whom, is enough.

Cangas de Onís: life beyond the perimeter

Cangas first appears as an image preserved in Josefina’s photographs: damp stone houses, grass, the stony riverbank and children crossing the water from rock to rock. Decades later, Alonso arrives by helicopter. The disproportionate choice of transport sums up the clash between the two worlds.

Alba, a teacher of young children, lives here. Her house, the geraniums, white sheets, meadows and air do not amount to a rural idealisation. They offer a moral and sensory contrast to Madrid: against sophisticated opacity, a life Alonso first interprets as deprivation and then as freedom.

Cangas does not magically save the protagonist. It takes away his usual tools. Here his surname, seduction, money and threats are useless. Alba can gently close a door and deliver a deeper condemnation than any interrogation.

75%

OF AN INHERITANCE

The place where money discovers that it is not the only form of wealth.

A voice that accuses and gives itself away

> *“The day my father died, I was spilling my seed into an intern with hunger in her eyes…”*

FIRST PERSON

Alonso controls the information, but not always its meaning. His observations reveal prejudice, fear and a need for superiority even when he intends to demonstrate insight.

BLACK HUMOUR

The comedy comes from the precision with which the narrator demeans ceremonies, elites and, frequently, himself. Humour does not soften the rot: it makes it recognisable.

MORAL RHYTHM

The corporate intrigue advances alongside conscience. Each document uncovered adds an external risk and changes Alonso’s image of his father and himself.

AN UNSETTLING NARRATOR

His misogyny, class prejudice and cynicism are dramatic material, rather than the novel’s credo. The reader must maintain a critical distance without losing access to his inner life.

THE LANGUAGE OF POWER

Contracts, sovereign wealth funds, takeover bids, patents and companies are not technical decoration. They translate into procedures what the characters refuse to call violence.

THE POSSIBILITY OF REDEMPTION

The novel takes Alonso to a point where understanding his degradation is no longer enough. The question is whether he can act against the logic that made him powerful.

The voice of Miseria

Four passages into Alonso's consciousness: appearances, inheritance, intimacy and desire as an alibi.

APPEARANCES

"Perhaps the world has always been like this; perhaps we are nothing but a plague condemned to cultivate misery, all disguised as great and worthy figures, unhappy to the marrow, craving more and more and more. Always more."

THE INNER INHERITANCE

"What if the inheritance is not the company or the paintings or the surname, but this way of being dead inside? What if one day he wakes up and no longer loves, or desires, or believes? What if, without meaning to, I drag him with me into this hell where everything is appearance and nothing matters? What if I infect him?"

MARRIAGE

"In our house, silence had become a form of grammar. Almost the only one. […] Marriage as prolonged courtesy. Protocol and routine. Proper. Desolate."

DESIRE AS AN ALIBI

"I, who for years had thought only of fucking - yes, fucking: with determination, with theological conviction, with the blind obstinacy of someone who mistakes a spasm for heavenly redemption; I, who had fucked out of arrogance, boredom, spite and even some bastard form of ego; I, who even on receiving the publisher's humiliating letter informing me that barely a hundred copies had sold, had consoled myself with the image of a yielding body opening up, now could not even bear the sound of her voice.

[…] Perhaps I was becoming a misogynist. Or worse still, perhaps I always had been, and desire had merely been the ornamental alibi for my contempt."

Ten conversations opened up by Miseria

Ten human, moral and psychological dilemmas arising from a lucid, corrosive and unsettling voice.

THE CENTRAL QUESTION

When a man discovers that his fortune, power and image of invulnerability rest on betrayal, does he protect the sham that made him great, or dare to save himself from himself?

OTHER ANGLES

2
Can someone carry on a legacy of corruption without ultimately breaking inside?

3
Must we hit rock bottom to find redemption, or can suffering become another form of self-deception?

4
How can a successful life be sustained when outward appearances coexist with inner fracture and decay?

5
What do we really inherit from our parents: their assets, their guilt or their way of seeing the world?

6
Can someone truly love if they have learned to relate to others through domination, desire and possession?

7
What story do those who live on privilege tell themselves so they can still consider themselves reasonable people?

8
When does corruption stop being a series of crimes and become a way of life that contaminates families, affections and consciences?

9
Can someone benefit from corruption without being corrupt, or does benefiting already make them complicit?

10
Can one just act redeem a misguided life, or is there harm that no reparation can erase?

THE MORAL INHERITANCE OF POWER

How corruption, privilege and appearances take root in the conscience and in our most intimate bonds.

María Zabay

A law graduate, writer and journalist, she has worked in print, radio and television. She has presented programmes on TVE, TVE2 and Mediaset channels, and served as head of content in Spain for the international production company Digital TV Group. She was communications director at Spain's Ministry of Industry, Energy and Tourism. To date she has published seven novels, including El zapato de la lengua rota, La alumna, Aislada and Valentina, and co-authored three books on management. Manhattan won her the Válgame Dios Literary Prize for Erotic Short Fiction. She has contributed to publications including The Times, La Gaceta, Cinco Días, La Razón and OKDiario, where she currently presents El Foco, interviewing leading figures in culture, politics, science and thought.



A LITERARY CAREER WITH DISTINGUISHED SUPPORT

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Digital resources

Novel website
miseria.mariazabay.com

Official website
www.mariazabay.com

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@maria_zabay

Available press materials

Press release · Synopses in three lengths · Character profiles · Cover · Reading excerpt · Audiovisual resources · Publication details

PRESS CONTACT

Ada de Benítez
Tel. 630 603 318

"Greatness can also conceal misery."